

Face Acts Annotation Guidelines

Introduction

This guideline provides instructions for annotating text with face acts in politeness categories based on the politeness theory of Brown and Levinson. It defines the categories, examples, and decision-making principles for consistent annotation. These guidelines are based on theoretical underpinnings and practical use cases.

Annotation Granularity

1. Granularity:

Face acts operate at the **sentence level**. Each sentence is treated as a discrete unit for assigning face acts categories.

2. Face Act Categories:

There are 8 categories for annotating face acts, based on the speaker's (S) and hearer's (H) interactions and the type of face acts: **HPos+**, **SPos+**, **HPos-**, **SPos-**, **HNeg+**, **SNeg+**, **HNeg-**, **SNeg-**.

Face Acts Categories and Annotation Instructions

Definition of FTA (Face-Threatening Act):

An FTA (Face-Threatening Act) is any communicative act that risks damaging the speaker's or hearer's social identity or self-esteem by challenging their desire for positive regard (positive face) or their need for autonomy and non-imposition (negative face).

Key Aspects of FTA:

1. Positive Face Threats:

Actions that undermine a person's need to be liked, respected, or appreciated.

- Example: Criticizing, disagreeing, or showing indifference to someone's feelings or opinions.
- Example: "Your argument doesn't make sense."

2. Negative Face Threats:

Actions that impose on a person, limiting their autonomy or freedom of action.

- Example: Requests, commands, or interruptions that infringe on someone's independence.
- Example: "I need you to finish this by tomorrow."

Definition of FSA (Face Saving Act):

An FTS is any communicative act that enhances or supports the speaker's or hearer's social identity or self-esteem, by affirming their desire for positive regard (**positive face raising**) or respecting their autonomy and minimizing imposition (**negative face raising**).

Key Aspects of FSA:

- **Positive Face Raising:** Actions that support or enhance a person's need to be liked, respected, or appreciated.
 - Example acts: Complimenting, showing agreement, expressing empathy.
 - Example sentences:
 - "Your presentation was excellent."
- **Negative Face Raising:** Actions that acknowledge and respect a person's autonomy and independence, reducing perceived imposition.
 - Example acts: Using polite expressions, offering choices, minimizing urgency.
 - Example sentences:
 - "Would it be possible to have this completed by tomorrow?"

Key Aspects of FTS and FSA to annotate:

1. Hearer Positive Face Raising (HPos+)

Definition: Indicates when S positively acknowledges, compliments, or supports the hearer (H).

- **Annotation Rules:**
 1. S compliments H's skills, efforts, or traits.
 - Example: "You did a great job on this report."
 2. S implicitly incentivizes H to act positively.
 - Example: "Your creativity will really make this work stand out."
 3. S empathizes or agrees with H.
 - Example: "I completely understand your perspective."
 4. S shows willingness to comply with H's FTA.
 - Example: "I'm happy to revise the draft as per your suggestions."
 5. S expresses belief in H's abilities.
 - Example: "I know you can handle this challenge effectively."
 6. S uses a friendly and sincere tone.
 - Example: "It's always a pleasure working with you."

2. Speaker Positive Face Raising (SPos+)

Definition: Indicates when the speaker (S) expresses their own positive traits, competence, or preferences.

- **Annotation Rules:**
 1. S asserts their competence, skills, or positive traits.

- Example: "I am confident in handling this task."
- 2. S compliments the item they represent or endorse.
 - Example: "This proposal demonstrates our best efforts."
- 3. S states their preference or something they value.
 - Example: "I love the collaborative aspects of this project."
- 4. S positions themselves as knowledgeable or capable.
 - Example: "With my experience in this domain, I can assure success."

3. Hearer Negative Face Threatening (HPos-)

Definition: Indicates when S criticizes or challenges H, or fails to acknowledge H's contributions.

- **Annotation Rules:**

1. S voices doubts or criticizes H implicitly.
 - Example: "I'm not sure this approach is feasible."
2. S disagrees with H's stance.
 - Example: "I don't think that's the right interpretation."
3. S disregards H's preferences.
 - Example: "We'll proceed this way regardless."
4. S undermines H's efforts or contributions.
 - Example: "This part of your work seems rushed."
5. S implies H's shortcomings.
 - Example: "This could have been better planned."
6. S asks a rhetorical question that implies blame on the H's research quality, further challenging her/his positive face.
 - Example: "Could it be that the research isn't as comprehensive as required, affecting our team's performance?"
 - Example: "If only others managed their areas as closely."

4. Speaker Negative Face Threatening (SPos-)

Definition: Indicates when S downplays their own abilities, acknowledges their limitations, errors, or doubts.

- **Annotation Rules:**

1. S openly acknowledges mistakes or shortcomings.
 - Example: "I should have double-checked the data."
 - Example: "I'm aware the Todd Hall space isn't ideal."
 - I recognize that the current setup isn't perfect, and I am planning to reconfigure the space shortly.
2. S criticizes or humiliates themselves.
 - Example: "I am not as organized as I should be."
3. S expresses uncertainty or dependence on others.
 - Example: "I am unsure how to proceed without guidance."

4. S downplays their skills or knowledge.
 - Example: "I am not an expert in this area."
 - Example: "I may well not meet the lofty standards..." is a clear case of self-deprecation and acknowledgment of limitation."

5. Hearer Negative Politeness Raising (HNeg+)

Definition: Indicates when S seeks to minimize the imposition on H.

- **Annotation Rules:**

1. S reduces the inconvenience of the FTA.
 - Example: "Could you review this at your convenience?"
2. S apologizes for the FTA.
 - Example: "Sorry for asking this on short notice."
3. S makes an indirect request.
 - Example: "It would be great if you could take a look."
4. S provides a soft suggestion.
 - Example: "Perhaps we could consider this option?"
5. S makes a soft criticism.
 - Example: "It might benefit from a bit more detail in the budget section to ensure clarity for everyone."

6. Speaker Negative Face Raising (SNeg+)

Definition: S **rejects** or is **unwilling** to do the FTA. Stating the reason does not change the circumstances of non-compliance, but sometimes helps to mitigate the face act.

- **Annotation Rules:**

1. S rejects the FTA.
 - Example: "I'd like to look into this charity more before I donate as well."
 - Example: "I don't have much money for myself either, which is why I consider this to be my part-time job."
 - Example: "I already work full-time to make ends meet."
 - Example: "I do not wish to donate."
 - Example: "I may well not meet the lofty standards of your strategic vision, apparently because I'm neither a CEO nor a chairman yet."
 - Example: "I must disagree with your assessment as I believe I adhere to secure access protocols for EnronOnline."

7. Hearer Negative Face Threatening (HNeg-)

Definition: Indicates when S imposes an FTA on H, increasing the demand or urgency.

- **Annotation Rules:**

1. S imposes a significant demand or expectation.

- Example: "I need you to submit this by the end of the day."
- 2. S escalates the urgency of the FTA.
 - Example: "This must be done immediately."
- 3. S makes a strong demand.
 - Example: "You must complete this task."
- 4. S makes a promise, creating future expectations or obligations.
 - Example: "I'll handle this tomorrow."
- 5. S asks H a question that implicitly imposes an obligation, request, or responsibility.
 - Example: "When can you finish this task?"
- 6. **S issues a warning** or highlights a potential danger, implicitly urging H to take responsibility or action.
 - Example: "OPEC nations are not immune to this danger."
- 7. S makes a normative directive that applies to everyone, indirectly imposing a standard on the hearer.
 - Example: "It is fundamental that no one's contributions undermine the team's overall performance.."
- 8. Imposes a sense of responsibility. Setting a normative directive, assigning a consequence to the hearer's actions.
 - Example: Your ability to follow through impacts our overall team performance.

8. Speaker Negative Face Threatening (SNeg-)

Definition: It involves acts that enhance H's autonomy or mitigate a potential face-threatening act by offering help or reducing H's burden.

● Annotation Rules:

1. S directly offers assistance, help explicitly, reducing the potential burden on H, mitigating the imposition of a request or an action H may feel responsible for.
 - Example: "If you need any help setting up the new system, I'm happy to assist."
2. S Volunteers to share responsibility such that S takes on a portion of the work (sharing) or offers to contribute, reducing H's load.
 - Example: "I can review the final draft if it helps meet the deadline."
3. Indirect Offers of Support such that S frames assistance as conditional, putting the onus on H to accept. (purely supportive, without adding pressure on H.)
 - Example: "Let me know if you'd like me to follow up on this with the team."

4. S offers **support or shared responsibility**, with a **conditional**, no pressure unless the hearer desires it. Also, S **offers to share the process, not leave it to the hearer alone**.

- Example: "If you'd find it helpful, we could collaboratively review the current arrangements and identify possibilities for creating an even more supportive and efficient workspace."

Labeling Rules

1. Multi-Label Sentences:

Each sentence can carry **more than one label**, as sentences often express multiple face acts strategies simultaneously.

- Example: A sentence may show **SPos+** (asserting competence) while also expressing **HPos+** (complimenting the hearer).
- Annotation Example: *"I'm confident this solution works, and your insights on this have been incredibly helpful."* → **SPos+**, **HPos+**.

2. Mutually Exclusive Labels:

Opposing labels cannot coexist within the same sentence. For instance:

- **HPos+** (showing positive regard for the hearer) and **HPos-** (criticizing or undermining the hearer) cannot both apply to a single sentence.
- Similarly, other contradictory pairs like **SNeg+** and **SNeg-**, **SPos+** and **SPos-**, **HNeg+** and **HNeg-** are not allowed.

General Annotation Principles

- **Clarity and Consistency:** Use these rules to maintain consistent annotations across texts.
- **Uncertain Cases:** Flag ambiguous cases for review.
- In cases where a sentence appears to mix opposing elements, annotators should prioritize the dominant tone and context to resolve the conflict. If still unclear, flag the sentence for review.

Examples and Problematic Cases

- If asking a question implies an **expectation for action or responsibility**, it is **HNeg-**
- If asking a direct question is **purely informational, relational, or rhetorical**, it does **not qualify as HNeg-**. Example: *"How was your weekend?"* This does not place any burden or demand on H.

- The speaker's **offer** appears to impose an obligation on H. It would **not be a SPos-** (this might better align with **HNeg-**). *Example: "Let me know if I should step in and take over your part of the project."*
- The tone of the speaker's **offer** undermines H's autonomy or competence. It would **not be a SPos-** (this aligns with **HPos-**). *Example: "I can assist with this report, but only if you provide the necessary data by tomorrow."*
- In hierarchical contexts(power dynamics), a speaker's offer of help might feel condescending if framed poorly. *Example: "Do you need help understanding the guidelines?"* (This might undermine H's competence, aligning more with **HPos-**)
- I trust you'll prioritize this effectively. Is **HNeg-**, because also **imposes an expectation** that the hearer *will* act and prioritize accordingly.
- "Please address these points" is a direct request = imposition. **HNeg-**
- Both clauses **set a standard and expectation** ("is important," "will receive due attention") for the hearer's conduct, which is an imposition. **HNeg-**
- **"Warrant your attention promptly"** is an indirect but clear imposition—the hearer is **expected to attend to these tasks soon**.
- If "together" just signals **inclusivity or partnership** ("let's discuss together," "we might try together"), it is **not enough for SNeg-**.
- For SNeg-, the sentence should **offer to take on work, assist, or directly mitigate the imposition**.
- *"Let's work together on this—I can handle the data analysis if you'd like."* Here, "together" is followed by an **explicit offer** that reduces H's responsibility (**SNeg-**).
- I understand the Todd Hall space could be better. → **Neutral**. Sometimes, sentences that acknowledge a situation, especially with **"I understand..."**, are not direct face acts per your main categories, unless they are linked to a person's effort, competence, or agency. In this case, the sentence validates an issue but does not directly target any face wants.
- The speaker asserts their intentions. It would be **SPos+**